

OPENING REMARKS: PSCBC GENERAL SECRETARY : MR FRIKKIE DE BRUIN

The Council plays a central role in safeguarding collective bargaining, advancing social dialogue, and ensuring the effective resolution of disputes within the public service.

In an era defined by rapid technological change, heightened demands for transparency, and the need for sustainable governance, the PSCBC must position itself to remain resilient, credible, and innovative.

The 2026 Strategic Planning Session provides an opportunity for the Parties to Council to collectively reflect, strategize, and chart a course for the future, underpinned by principles of good governance, effective dispute management, and the enduring protection of collective bargaining.

As we gather here under the theme off:

“Collective Bargaining in the Digital Era: Building Trust, Managing Disputes, Ensuring Good Governance”

The theme underscores the importance of protecting the institution of collective bargaining while modernizing dispute resolution and governance processes through the responsible use of technology.

This Strategic Planning Session aims to:

- Reaffirm the centrality of collective bargaining as the cornerstone of labour relations in the public service.
- Strengthen dispute management mechanisms to ensure timely, fair, and sustainable outcomes.
- Embed good governance principles — transparency, accountability, and inclusivity — across all PSCBC structures and processes.
- Leverage technology and innovation to modernize labour relations, improve access to information, and enhance efficiency.

- Develop a shared roadmap for the medium-term, aligning priorities between the employer and labour.

To give effect to the theme and objectives, the following thematic areas will be discussed in a reordered manner, that will ensure a planning session with a coherent, future focused framework.

Clearly defined thematic areas provide structure and focus to the strategic planning session, ensuring that discussions are aligned with the agreed theme and objectives. A coherent, future-focused framework helps participants engage meaningfully with long-term priorities rather than isolated or ad hoc issues.

Additionally, thematic areas promote consistency across deliberations, support integrated decision-making, and improve the quality of strategic outcomes. They enable the organisation to translate vision into actionable priorities, ensuring that the planning session produces clear, relevant, and implementable strategic directions.

The following being the agreed to thematic areas to be discussed in this session;

Sustaining Collective Bargaining and Enhancing Dispute Resolution

Strengthening Governance and Advancing Public Service Professionalisation

Workforce Well-Being, Equity and Transformation

The Future of Work and Digital Transformation

Sustainable Public Service Funding, Fiscal Framework and Wage Policy

As we begin this strategic planning session, I want to emphasize that today is not just about creating a document — it's about shaping our future with intention.

The work that brought us here did not happen overnight. Significant preparation has gone into this moment — gathering insights, reviewing performance, analysing trends, and reflecting honestly on where we stand.

That groundwork gives us a strong foundation. It allows us to move beyond assumptions and focus on meaningful, informed decisions.

Strategic planning requires more than ideas. It requires candour, courage, and alignment. It asks us to think long-term while being grounded in today's realities. It challenges us to prioritize — because strategy is as much about what we choose *not* to do as what we choose to pursue.

The time we invest here will influence how we allocate resources, how we lead our teams, and how we measure success in the months and years ahead. This is important work.

So I encourage everyone to engage fully, speak openly, challenge constructively, and think boldly. If we do that, we will leave this session not only with a clearer plan, but with stronger alignment and shared commitment.

Thank you Program Director,

Frikkie De Bruin